The Film Industry

Production in Hollywood Today

The production system in Hollywood today is an amalgam of (1) a studio system that differs radically from that of the golden age described earlier and (2) independent production companies, many of which are “small picture” or “prestige” (non-genre) divisions of the larger studios. The term *studio system* no longer means what it once did: a group of vertically integrated, meticulously organized factories that employ large numbers of contract employees in the creative arts and crafts. Today there is no “system,” and the studios exist to make and release movies, one at a time. In addition, now that almost every studio has its own prestige “indie” division, very few producers are truly independent.

Table 11.5 | HOLLYWOOD STUDIOS AND INDEPENDENT PRODUCTION COMPANIES TODAY

Major Studio	Owner	Independent Production Companies Owned by Studio
20th Century Fox	21st Century Fox	Blue Sky Studios, Fox Searchlight Pictures
Columbia Pictures	Sony	Screen Gems, Sony Pictures Animation, Sony Pictures Classics
Paramount Pictures	Viacom	
Universal Pictures	Comcast	DreamWorks Animation, Focus Features, Illumination Entertainment, Working Title Films
Walt Disney Pictures	The Walt Disney Company	Disneynature, DisneyToon Studios, Lucasfilm, Marvel Studios, Pixar, Walt Disney Animation Studios
Warner Bros. Pictures	Time Warner	New Line Cinema, Warner Bros. Animation
Mini-Major Production Companies		
Lionsgate Films	Lionsgate	Summit Entertainment
Open Road Films	Tang Media Partners	
STXfilms	STX Entertainment	
The Weinstein Company	Bob Weinstein	Dimension Films

There are currently six major studios in the United States, as well as four independent producers that are referred to in Hollywood as *mini-majors*. The best known of these mini-majors are Lionsgate and Lantern Entertainment (formerly The Weinstein Company). There are, in addition, many other independent producers too numerous to list. In terms of numbers of films and earning power, the mini-majors and other independents have become more important than the major studios.

Because they dominate the international market, the major studios continue to define movie production in the United States. When one of the smaller studios has a larger corporate owner, the parent firm is usually the distributor. In addition, countless independent producers must distribute their movies through the “big six” studios if they want the largest possible audience and the maximum profits on their investments.